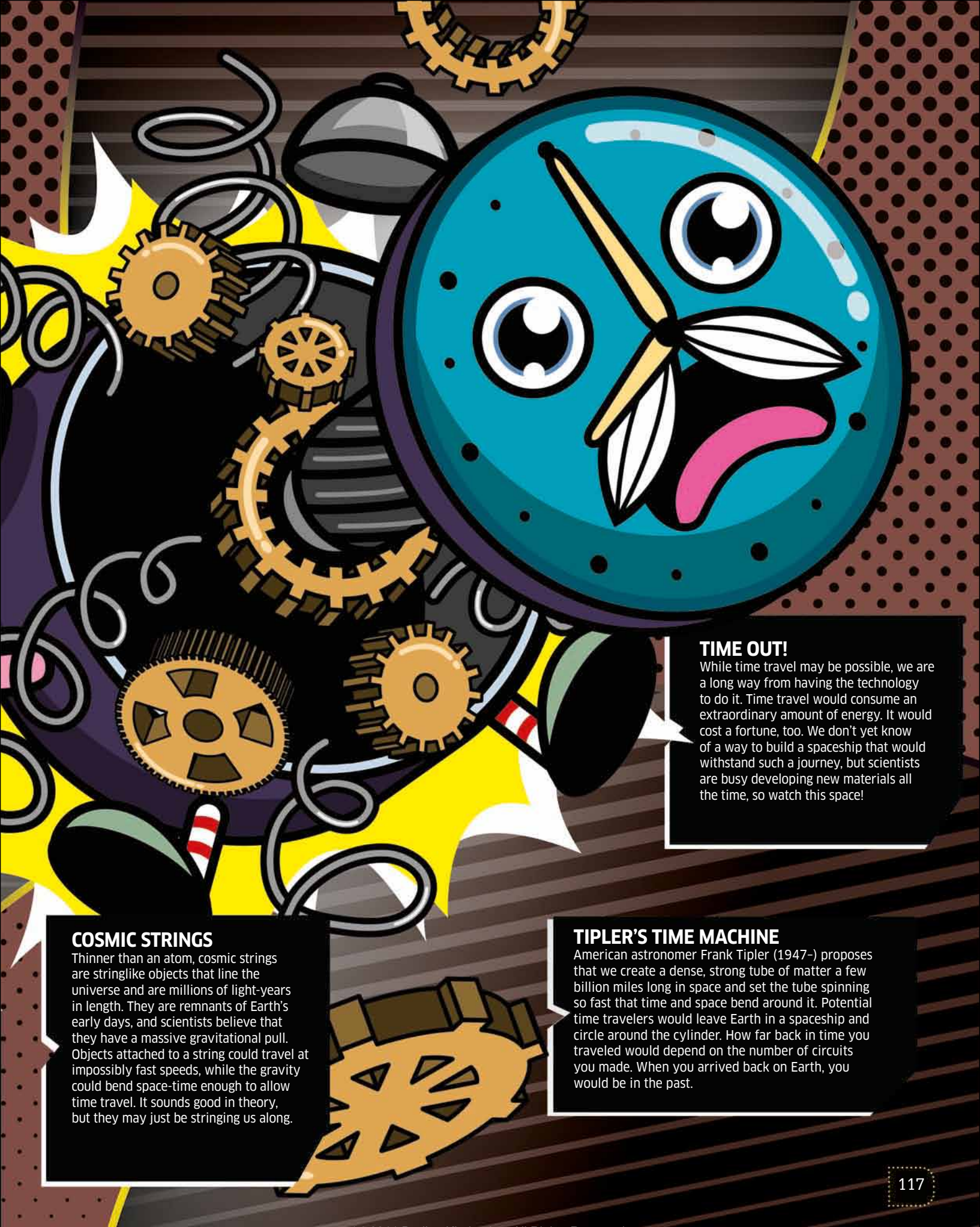




TIME OUT!

While time travel may be possible, we are a long way from having the technology to do it. Time travel would consume an extraordinary amount of energy. It would cost a fortune, too. We don't yet know of a way to build a spaceship that would withstand such a journey, but scientists are busy developing new materials all the time, so watch this space!

COSMIC STRINGS

Thinner than an atom, cosmic strings are stringlike objects that line the universe and are millions of light-years in length. They are remnants of Earth's early days, and scientists believe that they have a massive gravitational pull. Objects attached to a string could travel at impossibly fast speeds, while the gravity could bend space-time enough to allow time travel. It sounds good in theory, but they may just be stringing us along.

TIPLER'S TIME MACHINE

American astronomer Frank Tipler (1947-) proposes that we create a dense, strong tube of matter a few billion miles long in space and set the tube spinning so fast that time and space bend around it. Potential time travelers would leave Earth in a spaceship and circle around the cylinder. How far back in time you traveled would depend on the number of circuits you made. When you arrived back on Earth, you would be in the past.